

FBI Culture in the 1990s & American Law Enforcement Mindset

FBI Organisational Culture in the 1990s

In the 1990s, the Federal Bureau of Investigation (FBI) is a storied institution with a distinctive organisational culture. It is a federal investigative agency under the U.S. Department of Justice, not a local police force, and it prides itself on being America's premier law-enforcement agency. During this decade, the FBI transitions from the Cold War era into a new focus on violent crime and domestic threats. For example, after the late 1980s the Bureau reassigns hundreds of agents from counter-intelligence to violent crime and makes violent crime a top priority. High-profile incidents like the 1993 World Trade Center bombing and the 1995 Oklahoma City bombing lead the FBI to increase its role in counter-terrorism as well. FBI agents in the '90s often work cases involving organised crime, kidnappings, bank robberies, and emerging issues like cyber crimes, all while adapting to lessons learned from mishandled crises (such as the Ruby Ridge and Waco stand-offs, which prompt internal scrutiny).

The FBI has a rigid hierarchical structure and a clear chain of command. Field agents operate out of 56 main field offices across the United States (each led by a Special Agent in Charge, or SAC) and numerous smaller resident agencies. Above the field offices, FBI Head-quarters in Washington, D.C., sets priorities and policies. An agent in the 1990s is keenly aware of this hierarchy: important decisions or new techniques often require approval from HQ. For instance, initiating an undercover operation or a sensitive technique demands "multiple layers of approvals" from the Division (field-office leadership), FBI Headquarters, and even the Department of Justice. This bureaucratic oversight reflects a culture of caution and accountability; the FBI is not about to "invest significant time, effort, manpower, and money on some goofy idea" without vetting. Field agents sometimes chafe at HQ's micromanagement, but they generally respect that the FBI's centralised procedures aim to protect cases from legal challenges and uphold the Bureau's standards.

The workforce and daily environment of the FBI in the 1990s have their own cultural character. It is a predominantly white and male organisation at that time – in the mid-90s only about around 9% of agents are Black and similarly low percentages are women or other minorities. Senior leadership is even less diverse. This homogeneity contributes to a somewhat traditional, and some would say insular, culture. Agents often come from military or law-enforcement backgrounds and share a "G-man"¹ ethos of professionalism. Discipline and decorum are emphasised: agents adhere to dress codes (the classic suit and tie for investigators, or the FBI windbreaker jacket on raids) and maintain a clean-cut image. The FBI historically upholds strict standards of personal conduct (a legacy of the J. Edgar Hoover era), and while those loosen somewhat by the '90s, agents are still expected to be morally upright and beyond reproach in their communities. A strong sense of camaraderie exists – many agents describe the FBI as a "family" – yet it is also competitive. Performance is closely tracked, and achieving results (solving a case, making a big arrest) is a source of pride and a stepping-stone to promotion. An FBI agent's identity is often deeply tied

to their casework and Bureau affiliation, more so than to an ordinary job.

Core Values and Ethos of FBI Agents

The FBI's official motto, "Fidelity, Bravery, Integrity," succinctly describes the motivating force behind the men and women of the FBI. These three words are not taken lightly – new agents learn them from day one at the FBI Academy in Quantico, Virginia, and they permeate the Bureau's culture. Fidelity signifies faithfulness – to the Constitution, to the laws, and to the American people. Bravery reflects courage in the face of danger, a willingness to risk one's life to uphold justice. Integrity is perhaps the most cherished value: doing the right thing, adhering to a strict moral code, and being truthful and ethical in all actions. An FBI agent is expected to uphold the law while obeying the law – in other words, *to never break the rules in order to enforce them*. As one commentary on FBI culture notes, the Bureau's strength "must reside in a commitment to integrity and the rule of law," with an organisational culture committed to the fair and impartial administration of justice. This means an agent should not plant evidence, lie in court, or abuse authority; doing so violates their core ethos and also likely ruins a case and career. The emphasis on integrity is reinforced by internal-affairs units and by the knowledge that an agent's actions are often scrutinised in court by defence attorneys and judges. The culture teaches: if you cheat or cut corners, the case falls apart and justice is not served.



Figure 1: FBI agent exemplifying the expected dress code of male agents: dark suit, white shirt, tie, and dark shoes.

1 Short for "Government man", see nearby text box.

Patriotism and duty run strong in the FBI mindset. FBI agents swear an oath to uphold the U.S. Constitution and to protect the United States against all enemies. Many agents genuinely internalise a sense of mission, viewing their work as a public service and a calling to safeguard society. In the 1990s, immediately after the Cold War, there is still a lingering sense of being guardians on the domestic front – protecting Americans from violent criminals, spies, and terrorists. This instils a higher-purpose mentality. Agents often frame their work as keeping the country and its people safe. For North-European observers, this American patriotic zeal might stand out; FBI offices prominently display the American flag, and ceremonies or speeches by FBI leaders frequently invoke the ideals of American democracy and freedom. The FBI's heritage (going after gangsters like Dillinger in the 1930s, fighting civil-rights violations in the 1960s, etc.) forms part of its institutional pride. Thus, an FBI agent in the '90s likely sees themselves as heir to a proud tradition. They also tend to believe strongly in the rule of law – the idea that no one (not even government officials) stands above the law. This belief is reinforced by training in

The "G-man ethos"

Refers to the professional culture and mindset traditionally associated with federal law enforcement agents, particularly FBI agents. The term "G-man" (short for "Government man") became popular in the 1930s during J. Edgar Hoover's tenure as FBI director.

The G-man ethos typically encompasses several key characteristics:

Professional Standards

- * Rigorous attention to detail and procedure
- * Emphasis on thorough investigation and evidence-gathering
- * Strict adherence to chain of command and protocol
- * High standards for personal conduct and appearance

Institutional Loyalty

- * Strong dedication to the agency and its mission
- * Emphasis on the collective reputation over individual recognition
- * Willingness to subordinate personal interests to institutional goals

Methodical Approach

- * Systematic, patient investigative work
- * Preference for building airtight cases through meticulous evidence collection
- * Long-term strategic thinking rather than quick fixes

Moral Authority

- * Presentation of federal agents as incorruptible defenders of law and order
- * Emphasis on being above local politics and corruption
- * Cultivation of an image as elite, professional crime fighters

Discretion and Secrecy

- * Ability to work quietly and maintain confidentiality
- * Comfort with operating behind the scenes
- * Understanding that much of the work won't receive public recognition

This ethos was heavily promoted during the 1930s-1960s era and became part of American popular culture through movies, radio shows, and later television, though the reality of federal law enforcement has always been more complex than this idealised image suggests.

constitutional law and differentiates the FBI's law-enforcement mindset from, say, an intelligence agent's mindset. In fact, it is often said (half-jokingly) that "the FBI enforces the law, and the CIA breaks the law" – highlighting that FBI agents see their role as catching criminals within a legal framework, whereas CIA officers operating abroad might bribe, steal, or worse in the national interest. This underscores that an FBI agent's mentality is bound by legal process and ethical norms: evidence and due process are their tools to put "bad guys" behind bars, rather than secretive or extrajudicial methods.

Another aspect of FBI ethos is a sense of elitism and responsibility. The FBI considers itself the "premier" law-enforcement agency, and agents are highly trained (new agents in the '90s undergo approximately 16 weeks of intensive training at Quantico). They develop specialised skills in investigation, firearms, and forensic techniques. As a result, FBI agents in the field often act with confidence and authority. They usually take charge at major crime scenes that fall under federal jurisdiction, and they coordinate task forces. Local police sometimes perceive them as aloof or arrogant ("the Feds" or "Feebs" in cop slang), but from the FBI agent's perspective, they are simply upholding the high standards of the Bureau. This can manifest as meticulous attention to detail (for instance, ensuring all paperwork, like search warrants and reports, is perfectly in order) and adherence to SOPs (Standard Operating Procedures). In the '90s, the Bureau also modernises – incorporating DNA analysis, profiling techniques from its Behavioral Science Unit, and early computer-crime units – which further reinforces the notion that the FBI is on the cutting edge of law enforcement. All of this feeds into the mindset of an FBI agent as someone professional, incorruptible, and relentlessly driven by duty.

Life as a Field Agent in the 1990s

From the outside, FBI agents in the '90s are often depicted in movies and books as either suit-clad detectives or tactical SWAT-style operatives busting through doors. The reality of a field agent's life is somewhat less action-packed, however, encompassing both the mundane and the adrenaline-fuelled. A typical FBI field agent is assigned to a squad specializing in a certain crime type (e.g., organised crime, white-collar crime, violent crimes, drugs, etc.) at a field office. Day-to-day work involves a lot of investigation legwork: interviewing witnesses and suspects, conducting surveillance, gathering and analysing evidence, coordinating with local law enforcement, and writing reports. Despite the glamorous image, a substantial part of an FBI agent's time is spent at a desk – documenting case files, filling out forms (to comply with legal requirements and Bureau procedures), and discussing strategy with colleagues. Agents joke about "doing the paperwork," but they understand that detailed documentation is essential to build a prosecutable case. The end goal is usually a federal prosecution, so everything the agent does must withstand scrutiny in court. This means they have to be methodical and follow rules (for instance, observing Fourth-Amendment² protections – no illegal searches or seizures without a warrant or an exception). An FBI case might unfold over months of pain-staking work before culminating in an arrest or indictment. When it comes time to take action, FBI agents in the field gear up and partner with others. Teamwork is key. Unlike the lone-detective stereotype, in real FBI operations agents work in pairs or squads. Arresting a suspect, for example, typically involves multiple agents and often local-police backup for perimeter security. The FBI emphasises careful planning for raids or arrests – often holding briefings beforehand to cover

2 The Fourth Amendment to the U.S. Constitution stipulates: "The right of the people to be secure in their persons, houses, papers, and effects, against unreasonable searches and seizures, shall not be violated, and no Warrants shall issue, but upon probable cause, supported by Oath or affirmation, and particularly describing the place to be searched, and the persons or things to be seized."

assignments, danger points, and rules of engagement. By the 1990s, each FBI field office has a SWAT team for high-risk arrests, and the elite Hostage Rescue Team (HRT) can deploy for major incidents. A regular agent might or might not be on SWAT, but all agents are trained and expected to handle firearms. They carry a standard-issue pistol (in the '90s, often a Glock .40 caliber) and must qualify at the shooting range regularly. Still, the default image of a '90s agent on duty is a person with a badge on the belt or in a coat pocket, not a uniform – FBI agents do not wear uniforms – which symbolises that they are investigators, not patrol officers. They identify themselves with a badge and ID and sometimes the iconic blue or dark FBI jacket with yellow lettering during field operations.

Field agents navigate relationships with both local law enforcement and the FBI's internal bureaucracy. On one hand, they often depend on local police for leads and assistance, since local cops know the terrain and community. The relationship can be cooperative (joint task forces against gangs or mobsters are common, combining FBI resources with local knowledge) but occasionally tense if jurisdictions clash. For example, in a bank robbery that also violates federal law, the FBI asserts jurisdiction, which requires diplomatic skill to avoid alienating the city detectives who arrive first. Culturally, FBI agents tend to see themselves as more accountable to the law and less likely to bend rules than some local counterparts – they have to remind locals that evidence must be obtained legally or the case can be lost. On the other hand, within the Bureau, a field agent answers to supervisors, and major decisions need supervisor sign-off or HQ approval. Agents regularly communicate with FBI Headquarters on priority cases, and if a case spans multiple states, they “set a lead” (i.e., request information or action) from another field office. This teaches agents to be collaborative across the Bureau's offices, but it can also be frustrating when bureaucratic delays occur. Nonetheless, by the 1990s the FBI has a well-oiled system for interstate investigations, and agents take pride in how the Bureau can “throw the net” nationwide to catch fugitives or coordinate on big cases.



Figure 2: Female FBI agent, one of a still relatively small, but growing number in the 1990s.

An FBI agent's life on the job can vary widely day by day. One day might be spent combing financial records or listening to

wiretap audio; another might involve knocking on doors in rough neighbourhoods or orchestrating the takedown of a dangerous suspect. There is also an element of mobility – agents are often required to serve wherever needed. A new agent out of Quantico in the '90s can be assigned far from home (perhaps a Boston native sent to the Los Angeles office), which is a notable cultural difference from many European police forces where officers usually serve in their home country and often near their home towns. This aspect of FBI culture fosters a certain adaptability and a national perspective. Agents move around the U.S. during their career, getting to know the diversity of American society. It also means that within the FBI, loyalty is first and foremost to the Bureau itself rather than to a city or state. Agents are part of a national force and think in those terms.

Morale and identity are bolstered by the sense of doing important work, but the job is not without its stresses. The FBI in the '90s faces some criticism and crises (e.g., the above-mentioned Waco siege in 1993, where the FBI's handling draws controversy). Field agents feel this acutely, and it leads to a degree of introspection in the culture – negotiation tactics improve and use-of-force policies are reviewed. There is also the looming shift toward terrorism prevention toward the end of the '90s; by 1998 the FBI has a strategic plan prioritizing counter-terrorism as a Tier 1 priority. For a field agent, that means more training and briefings on terror threats, even if day-to-day they still mostly chase bank robbers or fraudsters. In summary, the life of an FBI field agent in this era is a mix of diligent investigative grind, interspersed with moments of high drama – all carried out under a culture that stresses professionalism, fidelity to the law, and allegiance to the Bureau's proud traditions.

The American Law Enforcement Mindset and Ethos

To understand FBI culture, it is helpful to see it as one part of the broader American law-enforcement ethos. Law enforcement in the United States (spanning local police, state police, federal agents like the FBI, etc.) traditionally embraces a “warrior” self-image – especially pronounced in the 1980s and 1990s during the “war on drugs” and tough-on-crime era. Police and agents see themselves as the front-line soldiers in a war against crime and chaos. A popular analogy, taught in police and military circles, is that of sheep, wolves, and sheepdogs. Most citizens are the innocent “sheep”; violent criminals are the “wolves” who prey on society “without mercy”; and law-enforcement officers are the “sheepdogs,” the protectors who live to confront the wolves and guard the flock. This mindset, articulated by figures like Lt. Col. Dave Grossman³, casts the police/FBI as heroic guardians who must be ever vigilant and ready to use force to stop evil. An FBI agent likely identifies with this protector role – they have “a capacity for violence, and a deep love for [their] fellow citizens,” which makes them “a sheepdog, a warrior... walking the hero's path” in Grossman's words. Such framing might seem melodramatic to a European audience, but it genuinely underpins much of American law-enforcement culture. It justifies strong action: if “evil” is out there, an officer or agent must be brave and might have to be violent to stop violence (all in the service of good). There is “a clear picture of the roles” in this world view – good versus evil, protector versus predator.

Another concept in the U.S. police ethos is the “Thin Blue

3 American author and former Lt. Col. In the U.S. Army who conducts seminars on the psychology of lethal force. Known for his books “On Killing: The Psychological Cost of Learning to Kill in War and Society” and “On Combat: The Psychology and Physiology of Deadly Conflict in War and in Peace”.

Line.” This metaphor describes law enforcement as the thin line that stands between order and anarchy, between the public and the criminal element. It engenders a kind of us-versus-them mentality: us (the officers/agents in blue) versus them (criminals, and sometimes by extension anyone who might obstruct the mission). In the FBI, which wears suits not blue uniforms, the idea still applies – agents see themselves as the barrier preventing society from descending into violence and lawlessness. This can foster enormous solidarity: an attack on one agent is felt by all as an attack on the side of law and order. It also can create an expectation that agents support each other unconditionally in the face of danger. For example, during the famous 1986 FBI Miami shoot-out (a deadly firefight with bank robbers), agents showed extraordinary heroism and teamwork, which became part of FBI lore and training lessons about courage and not giving up the fight. Such events reinforce the narrative that FBI agents must be willing to risk their lives and even die to protect innocent lives – a level of sacrifice that is highly honoured in the culture. The Wall of Honour at FBI Headquarters, listing agents killed in the line of duty, receives reverence. This is quite similar to how police in most countries honour their fallen, though the scale of violent encounters in the U.S. is notably higher.

Crucially, the American law-enforcement mindset in the '90s is also characterised by a readiness to use force and a confidence in the righteousness of doing so when necessary. Police and agents train in firearms and tactical driving and defensive tactics, preparing for worst-case scenarios. They generally hope to resolve situations peace-fully, but they practice for gunfights. In the United States, because firearms are widespread among the population (including criminals), officers approach suspects with an assumption that danger can strike at any moment. This leads to a more assertive and often aggressive style of policing than what is common in Scandinavia. FBI agents, for instance, never execute a search warrant unarmed; they typically have guns drawn and a plan for armed resistance. The overarching principle hammered into American officers is “Officer Safety” – meaning the first priority is to ensure no harm comes to law enforcement or innocents, even if that means using force quickly to control a situation. The cultural ethos holds that it is better for a cop/agent to overpower a suspect early than to hesitate and possibly be injured or let a civilian be hurt.

We also see an individualistic and achievement-oriented streak in American law-enforcement ethos. The FBI, in particular, is described as valuing “very concrete, quantifiable things, such as arrests and suspects,” and valuing individual achievement. Agents are somewhat competitive, as mentioned – a successful case can make your reputation. In the wider police culture, this translates to a focus on arrests and crime stats as measures of success. By contrast, in some European contexts the emphasis might be more on conflict resolution or crime prevention than sheer arrest numbers. An FBI agent’s mindset in the '90s equates success with putting “bad guys behind bars”. That phrase itself – “bad guys” – is telling. It reflects a supposition of moral clarity: the people they pursue are viewed as the bad guys, not misguided individuals to be rehabilitated (that part is left to courts and corrections). The agent’s job is to catch them and ensure they are prosecuted. This crime-fighting ethos is deeply ingrained. It is not that agents are unthinking or do not see nuances (many understand social factors in crime), but culturally they approach each case with a sense of right and wrong, victim and perpetrator, and feel duty-bound to be the instrument of justice.

Finally, American law enforcement tends to be less formal in social distance but more formal in procedure compared to Scandinavian norms. An American FBI agent might call a colleague or even superior by their first name (American

workplace culture is generally informal in daily speech), and station-house banter or dark humour (gallows humour) is common as a coping mechanism. However, when it comes to procedure, Americans are very strict: there is a rule and form for nearly everything. A search, an interrogation, an evidence collection – all have specific protocols that must be followed to the letter. This procedural formality is part legal necessity and part culture of rigour. Scandinavian police, who operate in a high-trust society, might be surprised by how mistrustful American cops are during interactions (the assumption that a person might become violent or deceitful is always there) and by how much paperwork and legal formalities are involved at every step. But this is how American cops and agents manifest their ethos: trust no criminal suspect too far, and cover every base to get the conviction.

U.S. vs. Scandinavian Approaches: Key Cultural Differences

While both American and Scandinavian law enforcement share the fundamental goal of public safety, there are several subtle (and not-so-subtle) cultural differences in their approach and mindset. For Scandinavian players trying to portray FBI agents, understanding these contrasts helps in adopting an American FBI mindset authentically:

- **Hierarchy and Formality:** U.S. law-enforcement agencies, including the FBI, are organised in a quasi-military hierarchy with clear ranks (e.g., Special Agent, Supervisory Special Agent, Assistant Special Agent in Charge, etc.). Orders from superiors are expected to be followed, and there is a strong concept of command. In Scandinavian countries, policing tends to be more centralised nationally (for example, all the Nordic countries’ police forces are unified into single national services) and often more egalitarian in workplace culture. While Scandinavian officers respect rank, the societal norm of equality might make their inter-actions feel less deferential than in the U.S. By contrast, an FBI agent typically does not question orders openly – they follow the case plan given by the boss, except in extreme moral conflicts. Also, the FBI has a lot of internal bureaucracy – memorandums, case reports, official approvals – which might seem excessive to outsiders but is ingrained in the culture (it ties back to integrity and accountability). So, an FBI agent character is accustomed to “checking with HQ” or “clearing things with the SAC” before acting.



Figure 3: Typical FBI SAC (Special Agent in Charge).

- **Training and Use of Force:** Perhaps one of the biggest differences lies in police training and attitude toward force. Scandinavian police receive lengthy training with heavy emphasis on conflict de-escalation. For instance, Sweden requires about two and a half years of training for new officers, focusing on communication and resolving conflicts peacefully,

with firearms truly as a last resort. In the U.S., basic police-academy training can be as short as 13 to 26 weeks (3–6 months), and American training dedicates a lot of time to firearms, defensive tactics, and scenario-based use of force. American officers are “instructed to use force more than almost any other type of intervention,” and they get comparatively less training in unarmed techniques or verbal crisis intervention. The result: an FBI agent (and American cops generally) defaults to a commanding presence and escalates force quickly if they sense a threat. They are likely to shout commands like “Freeze! FBI!” with a drawn gun when making an arrest, expecting compliance. A Scandinavian officer might be more inclined to keep a weapon holstered and talk a suspect down. This is not to say FBI agents never negotiate – they have negotiators for hostage situations, for example – but in everyday practice, U.S. officers have a shorter fuse before using force because they train for worst-case scenarios. As a player, one should portray an FBI agent as constantly assessing threats and willing to use physical or even lethal force if a situation seems to be spiralling, whereas a Scandinavian cop character might err on the side of patience. The FBI agent might think the Scandi cop is naive about the dangers, while the Scandinavian police officer might consider his American counterpart a violent-prone cowboy.

- **View of Criminals and Justice:** Culturally, American law enforcement in the '90s has a more punitive outlook. Crime is high in the late '80s/early '90s, and the response is often zero-tolerance enforcement and long prison sentences. FBI agents, like most U.S. officers, likely believe that putting offenders in jail protects society and deters crime. In North Europe, there is (especially in recent decades) more emphasis on rehabilitation and understanding root causes of crime. To illustrate: Nordic sentences are much lighter than American ones. The average prison time for a murderer in, say, Finland or Norway might be 10–14 years, often with parole available after serving a portion of that. In the U.S., a murder might get on average 15 years or life; even those who do get out serve around 15 years on average. An FBI agent thus comes from a society that at that time overwhelmingly believes in strict punishment. They might talk about “locking up” bad guys and feel that justice is served when a criminal gets a long sentence. Scandinavian characters might find the American zeal for harsh sentencing (and the huge U.S. prison population) surprising, since in Scandinavia the focus is on rehabilitating offenders back into society. This difference in mindset could affect role-play: an FBI agent PC might show less sympathy for a criminal’s backstory (“He breaks the law, now he pays the price”), whereas a Scandinavian PC might be more conflicted. In the '90s context, the American agent certainly is not thinking about rehabilitation – that is not their job; their job is to catch and the court will punish.
- **Relationship with Society:** Generally, Scandinavian police enjoy a very high level of public trust and are seen as part of the community (helped by the fact that their approach is less confrontational day-to-day). In the U.S., public attitudes toward agencies like the FBI are mixed – many Americans respect the FBI as elite crime-fighters, but certain communities have deep-seated mistrust of law enforcement (e.g., due to

incidents of racial bias or historical abuses like surveillance of civil-rights leaders). In the 1990s, the FBI still carries a largely positive image in mainstream culture (movies and TV often portray FBI agents as competent heroes), but there are undercurrents of scepticism, especially among groups like far-right militia members or minority communities. An FBI agent, aware of events like the 1992 Ruby Ridge incident or 1993 Waco siege, might be defensive about the Bureau’s reputation. They see themselves as the “good guys” but know not everyone sees it that way. By contrast, a Scandinavian might be used to police being broadly accepted as good guys without question. This could translate into role-play as an FBI character perhaps being more guarded or using their status carefully – flashing the badge can intimidate or reassure depending on the person, and an agent might be ready for either reaction. Also, American agents might be more accustomed to the idea of political oversight and media scrutiny. The FBI in the '90s has to answer to Congressional committees and news outlets if things go wrong. So they are conscious of procedural correctness partly to avoid scandals. A Scandinavian cop likely does not operate under the same media microscope.



Figure 4: Agent conducting forensic analysis

- **Scale and Resources:** The United States is a much bigger, more populous country with a far more fragmented law-enforcement system. There are around 18,000 law-enforcement agencies in the U.S., ranging from small-town police to big-city departments to federal agencies. By contrast, each Nordic country has a unified national police, as mentioned previously. This means an FBI agent expects complexity in jurisdiction – they think about whether something is a local matter, state matter, or federal matter. They might even have a bit of turf consciousness (“Is this our case or the locals’ case?”). Scandinavians might not be used to this patchwork. The FBI agent mindset includes being very clear on jurisdiction and authority. If you are portraying an FBI agent, you would likely assert your federal authority in certain situations (which might come off as assertive or domineering). For example, if a crime crosses state lines, the FBI steps in firmly because that is literally their mandate. The FBI also has far greater resources – in the '90s, the FBI has labs, better tech, more manpower to throw at problems than a local police department. This contributes to a bit of institutional pride (or arrogance, depending on your perspective) in dealing with local cops: the agent might take charge of a crime scene, perhaps saying something like “We’ll take it from here” if it is a federal case. In a Scandinavian context, that might feel strange because the idea of multiple overlapping police forces is less pronounced. Also, due to the geographical and population size difference between the U.S. and Scandinavian countries the

distinction between local, state and federal jurisdictions is probably unfamiliar.

In summary, the American law-enforcement mindset that an FBI agent carries is one of assertiveness, readiness for danger, unwavering belief in the rule of law as a weapon against evil, and loyalty to one's organisation. A Scandinavian mindset might place relatively more weight on consensus, minimum necessary force, and social context in policing. A North-European audience should recognise that an FBI agent comes across as more intense and perhaps uncompromising – shaped by a country that in the '90s experiences high crime rates and responds with tough measures. By understanding these differences, you can role-play the culture shock or learning curve your characters might experience. For example, Scandinavian characters in an FBI setting might initially be taken aback by the Americans' gun-forward approach or their black-and-white talk of good guys vs. bad guys, while American agents might perceive Scandinavians as too lax or idealistic.



Figure 5: Another typical FBI agent, c. 1991

Conclusion

The culture of the FBI in the 1990s is a product of American history and values, blending a fierce law-and-order mentality

with a strict code of integrity and professionalism. An FBI agent from this era likely sees themselves as a guardian of society – a disciplined, patriotic crime-fighter who follows the Bureau's motto of Fidelity, Bravery, Integrity in service of justice. They operate within a highly structured organisation, respect the chain of command, and are meticulous about legal procedures. Their mindset is coloured by the American law-enforcement ethos: confront crime head-on, protect the innocent, and bring the "bad guys" to justice, all while holding themselves to a high standard of conduct.

For a Scandinavian audience, some of this feels familiar (dedication to duty, desire to protect the public), but many nuances differ. The American FBI agent's world in the '90s is more hierarchical, more prone to using force, and more absolutist about criminals than the typical Scandinavian context. Remember that these agents come of age during a peak-crime era in a very large, diverse country, and their attitudes reflect that environment. By contrast, Scandinavia's relatively low crime and strong social safety nets foster a policing style that is less aggressive and more preventive.

In practical terms, a player-character FBI agent should exude confidence, speak in terms of mission and responsibility, and perhaps have a bit of swagger (not personal ego necessarily, but the assuredness of someone who knows they represent a powerful federal agency). They likely use more idioms of justice (e.g., "we're gonna put this guy away for a long time" or "nobody is above the law"). They might also compartmentalise emotions – FBI training encourages agents to remain calm and focused under pressure, using humour or camaraderie later to decompress. When in the field, they are all business.

By immersing in this cultural mindset, you as players can portray FBI agents convincingly. Your characters act with that distinctive American blend of idealism and pragmatism: idealism in their unwavering belief in the cause of justice, pragmatism in how they are willing to physically enforce it. And they carry the pride (and sometimes the burdens) of being part of the FBI "family." In short, understanding the FBI's culture – its rules, its expectations, its history – lets you step into your characters' shoes with confidence. You can react to in-game situations as an American agent would, whether it is by flashing a badge and taking charge, painstakingly following evidence protocols, or standing firm on a point of law or duty. Embrace that mindset, and you bring rich authenticity to your role-playing, making the game world all the more immersive and engaging for everyone involved.